864-A is an old trailer rail coach with rundown looks comprising first- and second-class compartments. But don't go by its looks; it's just due to its age and overuse. It has a strong backbone and a stronger heart and is fit and sturdy enough to ferry Mumbai's 'super-dense crush load', a term coined by the railways to describe extreme crowding on the city's suburban railway network.

It now runs on what is the Trans-Harbour section of the Mumbai railway, connecting the two cities of Thane and Navi Mumbai. Most of the EMU local trains on Mumbai's suburban network have been upgraded with the new Siemens class or Bombardier class trains under a World Bank-funded project. They are well ventilated, have sleek looks and provide a good riding experience. But a few old ones are yet to complete their service life. This particular old-fashioned class of train I am talking about is hated by the present generation of commuters for being 'stuffy, resembling a cage' and is often called a khatara (scrap). It, however, remains a feast for rail fans for it being 'art deco', a vanishing relic of the old DC electric era and having served an entire generation. Originally made by Jessop Kolkata, these class of trains have unique, rectangular symmetrical features as compared to the trains manufactured by the Integral Coach Factory in Chennai, which have become a more common feature now. This one is one of them. But wait to read about the exceptional story of this khatara 'cage' that has made its mark like none other!

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Let me take you back to the horrific day of 11 July 2006, a Tuesday. Covering the transport beat for *Hindustan Times*, Mumbai, I was at my desk when my editor, Samar Halarnkar, walked up to me and mentioned that there had been some kind of chaos on the railway lines, a fire or an explosion. I dialled my sources and officials frantically, but there was no clarity in what they said. My first instinct was to run to the nearest railway station to know what exactly had happened. Our office was then at Mahim, close to the railway station, and as I was about to reach there I could see a sea of people rushing away from the train station, some ambulances and police vehicles. I walked towards the station. I gathered that there had been a series of bombings on the trains. As I reached the station, there was pandemonium, with mutilated bodies being brought from the rail lines and